

CHARTER

The Declaration of Independence

One self-evident truth, one grievance, one pledge
— never the whole parchment at once. One
thought per page.

The Declaration of Independence

National Archives transcriptions. Labels are not the legal text.

1776 · 53 BITES

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— never the whole parchment at once.

Heading

In Congress

In Congress, July 4, 1776.

The unanimous Declaration of the thirteen united States of
America,

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Opening

When in the Course of human events

When in the Course of human events, it becomes necessary for one people to dissolve the political bands which have connected them with another, and to assume among the powers of the earth, the separate and equal station to which the Laws of Nature and of Nature's God entitle them, a decent respect to the opinions of mankind requires that they should declare the causes which impel them to the separation.

Text: National Archives transcription. Labels are not the legal text.

Self-evident truth 1

Created equal

We hold these truths to be self-evident, that all men are created equal,

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Self-evident truth 2

Unalienable Rights

that they are endowed by their Creator with certain unalienable Rights, that among these are Life, Liberty and the pursuit of Happiness.

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Self-evident truth 3

Consent of the governed

--That to secure these rights, Governments are instituted among Men, deriving their just powers from the consent of the governed,

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Self-evident truth 4

Right to alter or abolish

--That whenever any Form of Government becomes destructive of these ends, it is the Right of the People to alter or to abolish it, and to institute new Government, laying its foundation on such principles and organizing its powers in such form, as to them shall seem most likely to effect their Safety and Happiness.

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Prudence

Not for light and transient causes

Prudence, indeed, will dictate that Governments long established should not be changed for light and transient causes; and accordingly all experience hath shewn, that mankind are more disposed to suffer, while evils are sufferable, than to right themselves by abolishing the forms to which they are accustomed.

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Duty

A long train of abuses

But when a long train of abuses and usurpations, pursuing invariably the same Object evinces a design to reduce them under absolute Despotism, it is their right, it is their duty, to throw off such Government, and to provide new Guards for their future security.

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Necessity

Facts submitted to a candid world

Such has been the patient sufferance of these Colonies; and such is now the necessity which constrains them to alter their former Systems of Government. The history of the present King of Great Britain is a history of repeated injuries and usurpations, all having in direct object the establishment of an absolute Tyranny over these States. To prove this, let Facts be submitted to a candid world.

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Grievance 1

Assent to Laws

He has refused his Assent to Laws, the most wholesome and necessary for the public good.

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Grievance 2

Governors forbidden to pass Laws

He has forbidden his Governors to pass Laws of immediate and pressing importance, unless suspended in their operation till his Assent should be obtained; and when so suspended, he has utterly neglected to attend to them.

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Grievance 3

Representation in the Legislature

He has refused to pass other Laws for the accommodation of large districts of people, unless those people would relinquish the right of Representation in the Legislature, a right inestimable to them and formidable to tyrants only.

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Grievance 4

Unusual places of assembly

He has called together legislative bodies at places unusual, uncomfortable, and distant from the depository of their public Records, for the sole purpose of fatiguing them into compliance with his measures.

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Grievance 5

Dissolved Representative Houses

He has dissolved Representative Houses repeatedly, for opposing with manly firmness his invasions on the rights of the people.

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Grievance 6

Refused new elections

He has refused for a long time, after such dissolutions, to cause others to be elected; whereby the Legislative powers, incapable of Annihilation, have returned to the People at large for their exercise; the State remaining in the mean time exposed to all the dangers of invasion from without, and convulsions within.

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Grievance 7

Obstructed population

He has endeavoured to prevent the population of these States; for that purpose obstructing the Laws for Naturalization of Foreigners; refusing to pass others to encourage their migrations hither, and raising the conditions of new Appropriations of Lands.

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Grievance 8

Administration of Justice

He has obstructed the Administration of Justice, by refusing his Assent to Laws for establishing Judiciary powers.

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Grievance 9

Judges dependent on his Will

He has made Judges dependent on his Will alone, for the tenure of their offices, and the amount and payment of their salaries.

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Grievance 10

New Offices and swarms of Officers

He has erected a multitude of New Offices, and sent hither swarms of Officers to harrass our people, and eat out their substance.

Text: National Archives transcription. Labels are not the legal text.

Grievance 11

Standing Armies

He has kept among us, in times of peace, Standing Armies without the Consent of our legislatures.

Text: National Archives transcription. Labels are not the legal text.

Grievance 12

Military above Civil power

He has affected to render the Military independent of and superior to the Civil power.

Text: National Archives transcription. Labels are not the legal text.

Grievance 13

Foreign jurisdiction

He has combined with others to subject us to a jurisdiction foreign to our constitution, and unacknowledged by our laws; giving his Assent to their Acts of pretended Legislation:

Text: National Archives transcription. Labels are not the legal text.

Grievance 14

Quartering troops

For Quartering large bodies of armed troops among us:

Text: National Archives transcription. Labels are not the legal text.

Grievance 15

Mock Trial

For protecting them, by a mock Trial, from punishment for any Murders which they should commit on the Inhabitants of these States:

Text: National Archives transcription. Labels are not the legal text.

Grievance 16

Cutting off Trade

For cutting off our Trade with all parts of the world:

Text: National Archives transcription. Labels are not the legal text.

Grievance 17

Taxes without Consent

For imposing Taxes on us without our Consent:

Text: National Archives transcription. Labels are not the legal text.

Grievance 18

Trial by Jury

For depriving us in many cases, of the benefits of Trial by Jury:

Text: National Archives transcription. Labels are not the legal text.

Grievance 19

Tried beyond Seas

For transporting us beyond Seas to be tried for pretended offences:

Text: National Archives transcription. Labels are not the legal text.

Grievance 20

A neighbouring Province

For abolishing the free System of English Laws in a neighbouring Province, establishing therein an Arbitrary government, and enlarging its Boundaries so as to render it at once an example and fit instrument for introducing the same absolute rule into these Colonies:

Text: National Archives transcription. Labels are not the legal text.

Grievance 21

Taking away Charters

For taking away our Charters, abolishing our most valuable Laws,
and altering fundamentally the Forms of our Governments:

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Grievance 22

Suspending Legislatures

For suspending our own Legislatures, and declaring themselves invested with power to legislate for us in all cases whatsoever.

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Grievance 23

Abdicated Government

He has abdicated Government here, by declaring us out of his
Protection and waging War against us.

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Grievance 24

Plundered our seas

He has plundered our seas, ravaged our Coasts, burnt our towns,
and destroyed the lives of our people.

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Grievance 25

Foreign Mercenaries

He is at this time transporting large Armies of foreign Mercenaries to compleat the works of death, desolation and tyranny, already begun with circumstances of Cruelty & perfidy scarcely paralleled in the most barbarous ages, and totally unworthy the Head of a civilized nation.

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Grievance 26

Captives on the high Seas

He has constrained our fellow Citizens taken Captive on the high Seas to bear Arms against their Country, to become the executioners of their friends and Brethren, or to fall themselves by their Hands.

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Grievance 27

Domestic insurrections

He has excited domestic insurrections amongst us, and has endeavoured to bring on the inhabitants of our frontiers, the merciless Indian Savages, whose known rule of warfare, is an undistinguished destruction of all ages, sexes and conditions.

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Petition

Petitioned for Redress

In every stage of these Oppressions We have Petitioned for Redress in the most humble terms: Our repeated Petitions have been answered only by repeated injury. A Prince, whose character is thus marked by every act which may define a Tyrant, is unfit to be the ruler of a free people.

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British brethren

Enemies in War, in Peace Friends

Nor have We been wanting in attentions to our Brittish brethren. We have warned them from time to time of attempts by their legislature to extend an unwarrantable jurisdiction over us. We have reminded them of the circumstances of our emigration and settlement here. We have appealed to their native justice and magnanimity, and we have conjured them by the ties of our common kindred to disavow these usurpations, which, would inevitably interrupt our connections and correspondence. They too have been deaf to the voice of justice and of consanguinity. We must, therefore, acquiesce in the necessity, which denounces our Separation, and hold them, as we hold the rest of mankind, Enemies in War, in Peace Friends.

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Therefore

Free and Independent States

We, therefore, the Representatives of the united States of America, in General Congress, Assembled, appealing to the Supreme Judge of the world for the rectitude of our intentions, do, in the Name, and by Authority of the good People of these Colonies, solemnly publish and declare, That these United Colonies are, and of Right ought to be Free and Independent States; that they are Absolved from all Allegiance to the British Crown, and that all political connection between them and the State of Great Britain, is and ought to be totally dissolved; and that as Free and Independent States, they have full Power to levy War, conclude Peace, contract Alliances, establish Commerce, and to do all other Acts and Things which Independent States may of right do.

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Pledge

Lives, Fortunes, and sacred Honor

And for the support of this Declaration, with a firm reliance on the protection of divine Providence, we mutually pledge to each other our Lives, our Fortunes and our sacred Honor.

Text: National Archives transcription. Labels are not the legal text.

New Hampshire

Signers

Josiah Bartlett

William Whipple

Matthew Thornton

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Massachusetts

Signers

John Hancock

Samuel Adams

John Adams

Robert Treat Paine

Elbridge Gerry

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Rhode Island

Signers

Stephen Hopkins

William Ellery

Text: National Archives transcription. Labels are not the legal text.

Connecticut

Signers

- Roger Sherman
- Samuel Huntington
- William Williams
- Oliver Wolcott

Text: National Archives transcription. Labels are not the legal text.

New York

Signers

- William Floyd
- Philip Livingston
- Francis Lewis
- Lewis Morris

Text: National Archives transcription. Labels are not the legal text.

New Jersey

Signers

Richard Stockton

John Witherspoon

Francis Hopkinson

John Hart

Abraham Clark

Text: National Archives transcription. Labels are not the legal text.

Pennsylvania

Signers

- Robert Morris
- Benjamin Rush
- Benjamin Franklin
- John Morton
- George Clymer
- James Smith
- George Taylor
- James Wilson
- George Ross

Text: National Archives transcription. Labels are not the legal text.

Delaware

Signers

Caesar Rodney

George Read

Thomas McKean

Text: National Archives transcription. Labels are not the legal text.

Maryland

Signers

Samuel Chase

William Paca

Thomas Stone

Charles Carroll of Carrollton

Text: National Archives transcription. Labels are not the legal text.

Virginia

Signers

- George Wythe
- Richard Henry Lee
- Thomas Jefferson
- Benjamin Harrison
- Thomas Nelson, Jr.
- Francis Lightfoot Lee
- Carter Braxton

Text: National Archives transcription. Labels are not the legal text.

North Carolina

Signers

William Hooper

Joseph Hewes

John Penn

Text: National Archives transcription. Labels are not the legal text.

South Carolina

Signers

- Edward Rutledge
- Thomas Heyward, Jr.
- Thomas Lynch, Jr.
- Arthur Middleton

Text: National Archives transcription. Labels are not the legal text.

Georgia

Signers

Button Gwinnett

Lyman Hall

George Walton

Text: National Archives transcription. Labels are not the legal text.